

Navigating Language Dynamics in Martinique and Guadeloupe: Beyond Diglossia and the Continuum

Martinique and Guadeloupe have historically been considered diglossic societies, with French occupying (H)igh-prestige functions and Creole relegated to (L)ow-prestige domains (Saint-Pierre 1973, Lefebvre 1974, Jardel 1974, Hazaël-Massieux 1978). However, the diglossic model has been increasingly contested. Some linguists advocate for a linguistic continuum, highlighting the fluidity and overlap between French and Creole across contexts, which has led to a breakdown of clear-cut boundaries (Prudent 1981, Managan 2016). Finally, others like Bernabé (1982), propose a model that maintains diglossia while acknowledging a continuum.

Despite these attempts, none of the existing frameworks fully capture the complexities of current language contact dynamics in Martinique and Guadeloupe, especially since the standardization of Creole and its expanding role in formal domains which challenge the traditional functional distinctions. Considering Ferguson’s (1959) and Fishman’s (1967) definitions of diglossia, this work introduces and conceptualizes functional diglossia (the observed distribution of functions) and perceived diglossia (the speakers' beliefs/attitudes), placing them on two distinct yet interrelated axes, and links the former axis to social hierarchies and the latter to the creole continuum.

The proposed dual-axis model accommodates the complex language dynamics and attitudes in Martinique and Guadeloupe, accounting for phenomena such as code-switching, hybrid forms, while addressing the impact of the emergence of formalized written Creole in H domains. Additionally, this model can easily be adapted to other Creole contexts and offer a comparative lens for analyzing similar sociohistorical contexts with very different sociolinguistic outcomes, such as Haiti which shares a similar Creole continuum but vastly different functional/perceived diglossias.

Standard Language/High Prestige [++formal]	Kréyòl Grangrèk Formal Written Creole		Standard French Formal Written French
H Functions / [+formal]	- Gwo Kréyòl-	Mesolectal/interlectal Zone	
L Functions/ [-formal]			- Colloquial French -
Non-standard/Low Prestige [--formal]		- Frenchified Creole -	- Creolized French -
	Basilect	Basi-Mesolect	Acro-Mesolect
			Acrolect

Figure 1 - Description of Martinique's and Guadeloupe's Linguistic Continua

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